Decode Your Trauma Seminar - Day 4 Recording Notes

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🕒 Started at 8:43AM on 30 Apr 2026, lasted 31m

Decode Your Trauma Seminar – Day 4 Recording

🗓️ 30 Apr, 2026
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Outline

Day 4 Overview and Session Structure

- Day 4 of the Decode Your Trauma Live seminar focuses on the homeostatic balance of the nervous system, maladaptive stress responses, and the importance of cultivating a healing state.
- Previous sessions covered the events of trauma and the context in which core emotional needs were either met or unmet.
- The ECHO model acronym stands for Events, Context, Homeostatic shift, and Outcomes, describing how early life experiences echo through time.
- Tomorrow's final session will address the Outcomes component of the ECHO model, including anxiety, depression, self-esteem issues, relationship issues, and chronic health conditions.

Core Premise of Trauma and Change

- Experiences from decades ago continue to shape and impact present-day mental, emotional, and nervous system functioning.
- Past events cannot be changed, but how they manifest in the mind, heart, and nervous system can be transformed.
- Defensive walls built in childhood to ensure safety become the psychological prison that limits adult life.
- Learned responses to unmet core emotional needs cause individuals to transition from being victims of trauma to unintentionally perpetuating their own suffering.
- Habits, beliefs, emotional responses, and relational patterns can all be changed through deliberate work.

Maladaptive Stress Response Defined

- A maladaptive stress response is defined as a chronic state of sympathetic nervous system activation occurring even within a safe environment.
- One of the central challenges is that the nervous system continues to signal danger even when the surrounding environment is objectively safe.
- Acute stress involves a temporary spike in adrenaline and cortisol in response to an immediate threat, followed by a return to baseline regulation.
- Chronic stress occurs when the perception of threat does not subside, causing the nervous system to remain in a prolonged state of dysregulation.
- Normalization of dysregulation means individuals often fail to recognize they are living in a maladaptive stress state, much like a frog that does not notice gradually heating water.

The Four Stress Responses

- Fight, Flight, Freeze and Fawn: Four primary responses are activated when the nervous system perceives threat, namely fight, flight, freeze, and fawn.
- Fighting involves moving toward the threat, while flight involves escaping or avoiding it.
- Freezing involves an adaptive shutdown in which the individual becomes immobile in the hope that the danger passes.
- Fawning involves becoming accommodating, people-pleasing, or caretaking in an attempt to neutralize the perceived threat.
- These four responses are ancient biological mechanisms that operate identically whether the threat is a modern hazard or a predator from thousands of years ago.

Polyvagal Theory and the Nervous System States

- Polyvagal theory, developed by Professor Stephen Porges of the University of North Carolina, identifies the relationship between visceral experiences and the vagus nerve's regulation of the heart, lungs, and digestive tract.
- The vagus nerve, whose name derives from the Latin word for wandering, connects the brain to organs in the neck, chest, and abdomen.
- Two pathways exist within the vagus nerve, the ventral vagal path associated with safety and social connection, and the dorsal vagal path associated with extreme danger, collapse, and shutdown.
- Three nervous system states are identified as safe and social, fight or flight, and freeze or shutdown.
- Neuroception, defined as detection without awareness, describes how the body responds to stress signals before conscious awareness registers them.

Safe and Social State

- The safe and social state, also referred to as the healing state, is characterized by calm, regulated, and relaxed functioning.
- In this state, individuals naturally seek connection and send nonverbal cues of safety through voice tone, facial expression, and body language.
- Positive responses to others' cues of safety are also heightened, enabling genuine social engagement and intimacy.

Fight or Flight State

- Activation in the fight or flight state primes the body for action through the release of adrenaline, cortisol, and other stress hormones.
- Research demonstrates that individuals in a dysregulated state misread neutral facial expressions as threatening or angry.
- Confirmation bias emerges in this state, causing individuals to actively seek out and perceive threats even when none are objectively present.
- The nervous system responds not to objective reality but to subjective perception through the process of neuroception, reinforcing the cycle of dysregulation.

Freeze and Shutdown State

- Activation of the reptilian brain during extreme threat leads to dissociation, emotional numbness, and physical immobilization.
- Energy levels can drop to near death-like states as the system conserves resources by suppressing fight or flight responses.
- Professor Robert Naviaux's work on cell danger response explains that mitochondria, which serve as cellular energy producers, deprioritize energy metabolism in favor of danger signaling when threat is perceived.
- Reduced energy production during prolonged threat states contributes to fatigue, as resources are redirected toward maintaining protective survival responses.
- Recovery from freeze often involves passing back through fight or flight, which can manifest as shaking, a natural process observed in animals and humans alike during trauma healing.

The Safety Loop and the Mind-Body Disconnect

- The felt sense of safety resides in the body rather than in the mind, and cannot be achieved through cognitive effort alone.
- As dysregulation deepens, the mind accelerates its activity in an attempt to restore safety, while emotional disconnection from the body simultaneously increases.
- This dynamic creates what is described as the safety loop, in which the very

strategies used to feel safe paradoxically intensify the sense of danger.
- Emotional healing requires a regulated nervous system as its foundation, much like a distressed child needing a calm caregiver to receive genuine support.

Rating the Nervous System Exercise

- A one-to-ten self-rating scale is introduced to help individuals assess their current nervous system state.
- Ratings of one to three represent a calm, regulated, and authentically connected state.
- Ratings of four to seven indicate increasing activation, stress hormone elevation, emotional suppression, and a shift toward cognitive rather than felt processing.
- Ratings of eight to ten reflect significant shutdown, numbness, dissociation, or depersonalization.
- Tracking ratings at multiple points throughout the day, including upon waking, mid-morning, lunchtime, mid-afternoon, early evening, and before sleep, helps identify patterns related to specific circumstances, environments, and relationships.

The RESET Program Model

- The RESET program is a 12-week online coaching program designed to teach nervous system regulation as the foundation for healing trauma.
- Five sequential steps are outlined, beginning with Recognizing the current state of the nervous system.
- Examining how that state is being created follows as the second step.
- Stopping the thoughts, patterns, and behaviors that drive dysregulation constitutes the third step.
- Retraining the nervous system through repeated interruption and redirection forms the fourth step.
- Transforming the relationship to oneself, one's body, and the world represents the fifth and final step.
- Emotional healing is positioned as dependent on prior nervous system regulation, as attempting to process trauma in a dysregulated state prevents effective healing.

Addressing Common Questions

- Increased fatigue during nervous system calming work is explained as a natural transition from a tired-and-wired fight or flight state to a state where the underlying tiredness becomes fully felt.
- This type of fatigue is often experienced as a relief or release rather than

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a worsening of symptoms, signaling genuine healing progress.
- Achieving regulation while still surrounded by dysregulating environments requires both making external changes and developing internal self-regulation that is not dependent on external conditions.
- Building self-regulation reduces reliance on co-regulation and people-pleasing as strategies for maintaining a sense of safety.
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Next Steps

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- The seminar will continue with a final session covering the Outcomes component of the ECHO model and a deeper exploration of the RESET methodology.
- Participants are encouraged to engage with the free personalized assessment tool provided as part of the Decode Your Trauma series.
- Enrollment in the RESET program is presented as the recommended continuation of the work begun during the seminar series.
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Key Points

- Decode Your Trauma Live Day 4 focuses on the homeostatic shift in the nervous system (the "H" in the ECHO model) and why cultivating a healing state is essential for trauma recovery.
- The ECHO model recaps: Events (Day 2), Context and core emotional needs—boundaries, safety, love (Day 3), Homeostatic Shift (Day 4), and Outcomes (Day 5).
- A maladaptive stress response is defined as chronic sympathetic nervous system activation in a safe environment—a healthy stress response that has become stuck.
- Acute vs. chronic stress contrasted: acute stress produces a spike and natural return to baseline, while chronic stress keeps the nervous system perpetually activated.
- Four primary threat responses—fight, flight, freeze, and fawn—are hardwired survival mechanisms that can become maladaptive when the perceived threat never resolves.
- Polyvagal theory (Prof. Stephen Porges, University of North Carolina) maps three nervous system states: safe and social (ventral vagal), fight or flight (sympathetic), and freeze/shutdown (dorsal vagal).
- Neuroception—detection of threat without conscious awareness—explains why the nervous system responds to perceived danger even when the environment is objectively safe.
- People in fight-or-flight misread neutral facial expressions as threatening, creating a confirmation bias that sustains dysregulation and keeps the maladaptive stress response locked in.
- In freeze/shutdown, mitochondria deprioritize energy metabolism to prioritize danger signaling (Prof. Robert Navio's cell danger response), directly linking nervous system state to fatigue and reduced physical capacity.

- Healing requires a regulated nervous system first; attempting emotional processing while dysregulated is ineffective—regulation must precede emotional healing.
- Alex Howard introduced a 1–10 nervous system self-rating scale: 1–3 calm/regulated, 4–7 increasing activation, 8–10 shutdown/dissociation, with tracking recommended at multiple points throughout the day.
- Safety is a felt body experience, not a cognitive one; trying to think one's way to safety drives a "safety loop" where the coping mechanism deepens the very unsafety it tries to resolve.
- The RESET program—a 5-step model (Recognize, Examine, Stop, Retrain, Transform)—was presented as the structured follow-on to the Decode series for resetting the nervous system.
- Feeling more tired when beginning to regulate is normal—it reflects a shift from "tired and wired" fight-or-flight functioning to genuine rest, and is often experienced as a relief-type fatigue.
- Reducing dependence on co-regulation and external people-pleasing is key to sustainable recovery; the goal is autonomous self-regulation independent of environmental conditions.

Action Items

- [x] ~~Tim to post the assessment tool link in the chat.~~

Themes

- Homeostatic balance of the nervous system and its role in trauma recovery
- Maladaptive stress response: definition, causes, and perpetuation
- Polyvagal theory and the three states of the nervous system: safe and social, fight or flight, freeze/shutdown
- Neuroception: the body's detection of threat without conscious awareness
- The distinction between acute stress and chronic stress
- The four trauma responses: fight, flight, freeze, fawn
- The safety loop: how attempts to feel safe can reinforce feelings of unsafety
- Cell danger response and mitochondrial function in states of threat
- The ECHO model: Events, Context, Homeostatic shift, Outcomes
- The RESET model: Recognize, Examine, Stop, Retrain, Transform
- Emotional healing as dependent on prior nervous system regulation
- Co-regulation versus self-regulation
- Confirmation bias in a dysregulated state: perceiving neutral cues as threatening

Quotes

- "The walls of defense that we built to keep ourselves safe become the walls of the prison that trap us in our adult lives." — Alex Howard
- "We go from being the victim to becoming the unintentional architect or perpetrator or kind of continue of those things that we learn to do." — Alex Howard
- "A maladaptive stress response is a chronic state of sympathetic nervous system activation when in a safe environment." — Alex Howard
- "We don't actually see or experience the world as it is. We see the world through the lens of the state that we're in." — Alex Howard
- "The feeling of safety that we need exists in our body not in our mind. And you can't think your way to feeling safe." — Alex Howard
- "If we try to do the emotional healing while the nervous system is still dysregulated, it's like a distressed child going to a dysregulated caregiver. They don't get what they need." — Alex Howard
- "We need to learn to unhook our internal state from what's happening around us." — Alex Howard